

cratic right and that even the ruling Left Front never thinks twice before bringing life to a standstill.

Today, her long-drawn protests over the Tata Motors plant at Singur have brought the state Government, headed by Buddhadeb Bhattacharya who rolls out the red carpet for potential investors, to its knees. As things stand, Tata Motors would rather pack and leave rather than budge; the state Government is in a quandary having made promises all around and Banerjee is not ready to buckle down under any pressure to change her original demand of the land that had been

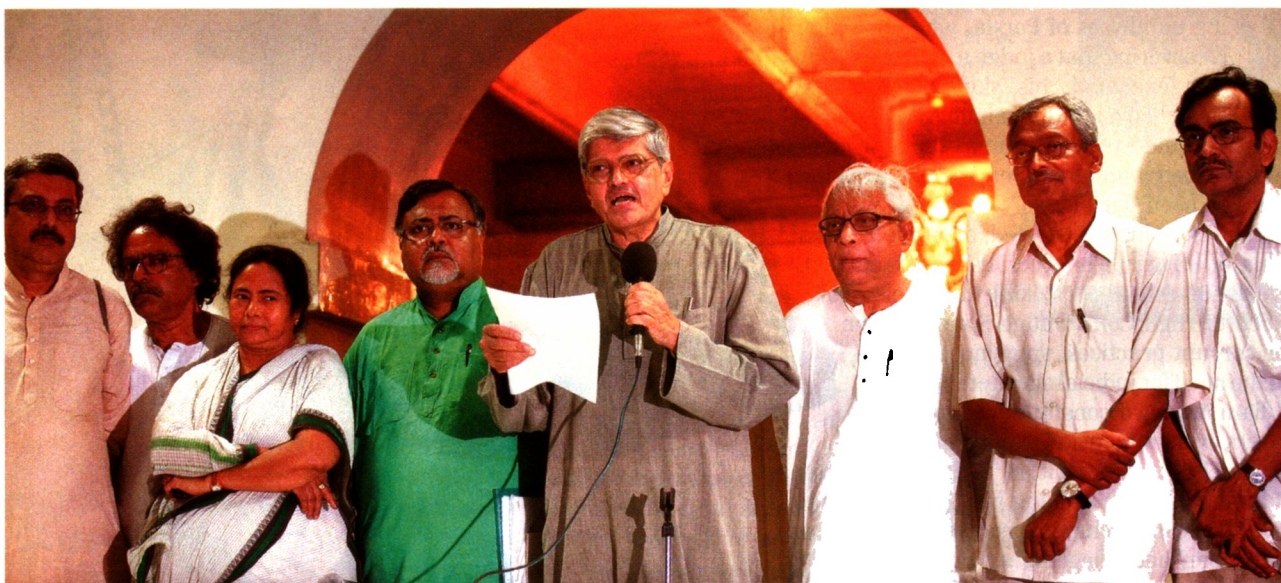
is that 300 acres of land be returned from within the project area but the State Industries Minister Nirupam Sen says, "It will be impossible to give back so much land from inside the project area. It would then compromise the initial agreement with Tata Motors, and for the project to be viable, the mother plant and the ancillary units need to be within that area."

The agitation by Banerjee is as old as the Nano project itself—in fact, it dates back to the time of its inception in May 2006. Her 25-day hunger strike in December 2006 had landed her in hospital. Even then the governor had

and was open to talks.

Round One to Banerjee; what next? If work at the Tata factory cannot start, will she still be the winner? In simple electoral politics, she may lose out on urban votes. Over the past fortnight, almost all of urban Bengal has clearly made its choice. For the urban pro-industrialisation lobby, Nano is the symbol. But Banerjee stands to gain from a large portion of the rural population which now holds her as a saviour.

BROKERING PEACE: At Governor Gandhi's (middle) initiative, Banerjee and Bhattacharya negotiated



taken from the "unwilling farmers" be returned to them. "There is no problem," Banerjee has repeatedly said since she sat across the table with Bhattacharya, under the watchful eye of Governor Gopalkrishna Gandhi. It was the first time the two had met and after hours of deliberations, and not without the expected drama, they came to a consensus. It was a moral victory for the Trinamool Congress supremo, since for the first time, the state Government relented from its original stance—that it is ready with a rehabilitation package but on no condition will the land acquired for the Tata project be returned.

Banerjee's success to a large extent lies in putting the Left Front in a spot like never before in 31 years of its uninterrupted stint in power. Her demand

Corporate India, which kept a close watch on Singur, is clearly worried and Banerjee's win may well be the state's loss.

tried to intervene but without much success. But this time it was solely due to his efforts that Banerjee and Bhattacharya were brought face to face in an effort to find a solution to the Singur imbroglio. Gandhi's patience over more than three days brought about at least a semblance of consensus between the two parties as Banerjee agreed to end her dharna

To them, no amount of compensation can make up for the loss of agricultural land and when it's time for payback, Banerjee is likely to be the beneficiary since she never gave up and even made the Left Front cringe in fear.

An immediate fallout of Singur has been Infosys Technologies voicing concern over the developments and hinting at having second thoughts about its proposed maiden venture in the state which entailed an investment of Rs 500 crore and would have employed 5,000 people. "Things are happening that make people and workers scared. It is causing a rethink among all companies in India at this point of time," T.V. Mohandas Pai, director HR, Infosys, said last week. Does it mean Banerjee's win may well turn out to be West Bengal's loss? ■